

HOW THE FRENCH REVOLUTION CAME TO BE

France produced two badminton world champions in New Delhi. A look at the decade-long system, coaching and investment behind its **historic breakthrough.**

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Carlos Rubio, the strength and conditioning coach of the French badminton team, had two bottles of Moët Champagne waiting in New Delhi's Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium on August 23. He'd bought them the day before, ready for the moment France finally produced a world champion in badminton.

When Thom Gicquel and Delphine Delrue beat top seeds Feng Yan Zhe and Huang Dong Ping to win the mixed doubles title, Rubio was waiting for them in the mixed zone, where players talk to the media after their match. As Gicquel and Delrue sauntered in with the gold medals around their necks, they were doused by Rubio with a foamy spray of bubbly.

A couple of hours later, Rubio would bring out his second bottle. Alex Lanier beat Kodai Naraoka to win the men's singles title and

complete a remarkable double for French badminton. Rubio sprayed him too.

Speaking to *Sportstar* while looking for a hiding spot from which to spray Lanier, Rubio said the team had tried to celebrate with champagne at the Thomas Cup in May. But amid the confusion of preparing for the final, they forgot to buy it. They finished second in that tournament. "I think one of the reasons was that we had forgotten to bring the champagne! This time we made sure we got two bottles from our hotel. You can say we manifested these world titles," Rubio said, perhaps only half-joking.

In a way, the bottles were a manifestation of what the French team had dared to believe was possible in New Delhi. They came looking for medals. They left with three world champions across two events.

"Two titles the same day, it's incredible," said Cyrille Gombrowicz, the French federation's technical

director. "We had thought we were going to win medals but maybe a bronze. Because at this moment we are competitive only in two events, men's singles and mixed doubles. And we try to work hard for other events also," he said.

It was a remarkable statement of where French badminton finds itself. The country has spent years trying to close a gap that once seemed almost impossible to bridge. By the time the championships reached their final day, France had delivered the result it had been chasing.

"France decided 'we want to win the title. But it's not easy'," Gombrowicz said.

Long time building

The ambition did not begin last year, or even when Gicquel and Delrue won France's first world medal produced by its own system.

It was the result of a process that Gombrowicz traces back more than a decade. He remembers a time when France was barely producing